ACTIVITY 17

Whale Rider (2003) is a film from New Zealand about a Maori girl who becomes the first female leader of her tribe, and her struggle to prove herself. Look at the posters for the film in **16** and **17**, and think about how they have been designed to appeal to the different audiences.

1 What does each poster suggest to you about the film?

2 What is each poster telling you about the girl?

3 Suggest how each one might appeal to its target audience.

Other ways to promote films

The poster works alongside other promotional techniques such as **newswraps**, magazine articles and newspaper articles, personal appearances by stars and directors on television, Internet advertising and items on news programmes to create interest in the film. These are seen particularly in the weeks before awards such as the Baftas and the Oscars.

ACTIVITY 18

Imagine one of your favourite films is to be released for the first time in another country.

1 In groups of three or four, plan a newswrap for the film. Think about:
   - which clips from the film would interest the audience
   - which characters you would focus on and stars you would interview
   - what background to the issues in the film you would include.

2 If the story would be difficult for people from another culture to understand, how would you take this into account?

3 Present your ideas to the rest of the class. You may be able to use clips from the film.



Trailers

Trailers in the cinema and on television give viewers a taste of the film itself and are designed to have maximum impact. Trailers on TV last about 30 seconds and are usually for films expected to be blockbusters, which have much bigger publicity budgets than other films. Like posters, they promote the film to the general public.

The cinema trailer, on the other hand, can target a particular audience – filmgoers. In fact, the films trailed are often of a similar genre to the main feature, targeting the audience more precisely – they offer the audience something like the film they have paid to watch. Cinema trailers are longer than TV trailers, often lasting a couple of minutes, and several trailers are shown. Unlike TV trailers, they have a **captive audience** who are waiting to see a film they have paid for.

Trailers are usually made by specialist companies. They have certain common features in order to convey in a couple of minutes a message that people will remember. The best bits of the film are often shown, and codes are used to give information quickly.

- **Action codes** use one action to indicate what is going to happen: a character is seen taking down a suitcase, so you know that they are going on a journey.

KEY TERMS

Captive audience people who, for whatever reason, are unlikely to stop consuming a media text

Newswrap video compilation including clips from the film, interviews with the stars and/or director and other background material given to television companies to use when covering a newly released film

- **Enigma codes** set the scene while giving very little away. A hand is seen writing a threatening letter. Who is writing the letter? Why?

Trailers often leave the audience with a question that can only be answered by seeing the film.

ACTIVITY 19

Watch some film trailers from a variety of different genres. In groups, list their features in a chart like the one below. How do these features make people want to see the film?

Genre	Features	How they make people want to see the film
Adventure	*Action scenes* *Fast-moving vehicles* *Loud sound track* *Deep-voiced male voice-over*	*People know the film will be exciting* *People like to feel they are driving them* *Young people like loud music* *People feel safe – someone strong is in charge*
Romantic comedy	*Characters are good-looking and fashionable*	*People want to look like that*



18 Still from the trailer to *Spider-man* (2002)

TIP

You can find trailers to study on videos and DVDs of other films.

Premieres and festivals

Lavish film premieres often hit the front pages of newspapers, particularly if the star is a glamorous woman, bringing the film to the notice of non-filmgoers. Celebrity magazines such as *Hello* will give such events extensive coverage, boosting the profile of both the film and its stars.

A film may also be shown at a festival. There are lots of festivals to choose from and awards to aim for, but care must be taken. Sometimes films that are successful at festivals can be regarded as too arty and as having less popular appeal. There are international festivals at Utah, Berlin, Cannes, Toronto, Venice, Santa Monica and Milan. The UK's two main festivals are at Edinburgh and in London. These are aimed at public audiences and are well sponsored. They show the best of new cinema from around the world.



19 Film premieres promote films and also stars – Orlando Bloom and Liv Tyler at the premiere of *The Lord of the Rings*

Distribution

Distribution varies from film to film. Films with big budgets may, in Britain, start with release in big London cinemas and then go on **general release**. Less highly financed films will appear at selected cinemas. Some films never make it to the cinema and go 'straight to video', either because their quality is thought to be poor, or because there is no money to promote them.

Spending huge amounts of money on making and promoting a film expected to be a blockbuster is no guarantee of box-office success. There have been many expensive flops, for example *Waterworld* (1995), starring Kevin Costner, which was said to have cost over US $150 million to make, was disliked by the critics and not an immediate success with the public, although it is believed to have made money eventually.

There have been surprise successes too. The box-office success of *Romeo and Juliet* (1996), directed by Baz Luhrmann, was so unexpected that not enough prints of the film were available! One of its stars, Leonardo DiCaprio (**20**), became a box-office draw, appearing soon after in the film *Titanic* (1997), which won eleven Oscars.

KEY TERMS

Distribution the process by which a film is released

General release when a film is shown throughout the country



20 Leonardo DiCaprio, a star of *Romeo and Juliet* (1996)

British film *The Full Monty* (1997) was a surprise hit for another reason. It was a low-budget film, so little money was spent on publicity and there was limited distribution. It proved to be a huge hit, mainly because people who saw it thought it was very funny and moving, and told their friends to go and see it. Before long, the film was packing out the cinemas all over Britain and it enjoyed success in the USA too. One of its stars, Mark Addy (**21**), appeared in several Hollywood films as a result.



21 Mark Addy appeared in low-budget film *The Full Monty* (1997)

Film classification

Before any film can be shown in the cinema or sold as a video or DVD, it must be assessed by a regulatory body to decide which age group it is suitable for. The BBFC classifies films, while the ITC grades videos and DVDs. You can see the BBFC classification scheme in **22**.



Universal: suitable for everyone.



Children under 12 can see the film only if accompanied by an adult.



Video release particularly suitable for pre-school children.



Not suitable for people under 15.



Parental Guidance: anyone can see the film, although some material may be unsuitable for children.



Not suitable for people under 18.



Not suitable for children under 12.



Video can only be sold through licensed sex shop.

22 The BBFC film classification scheme

UNIT SUMMARY

Key area	What you have learned
Media language	• What a narrative is. • How narrative is structured in stages. • How some narratives use subversions. • How modern films are often cross-genres. • The generic features of trailers.
Audiences	• How genre characteristics allow audiences to classify films. • How audiences are sewn into films to keep them interested and involved. • How film posters target national audiences.
Institutions and organisations	• How film companies promote films.
Representation	• How film posters represent women. • How science fiction films portray women and aliens.